

Today's Problems Come From Yesterday's Solutions

Of the eleven laws in Chapter 4, the one that best describes the major issue in healthcare is **“Today’s problems come from yesterday’s solutions.”** A problem that seems to arrive from nowhere is usually the downstream effect of a fix made earlier, elsewhere in the system, for reasons that were entirely sound at the time; because the fix and the consequence are separated by years and by organizational distance, nobody connects them. Dialysis is the clearest case I know. In 1972 Congress extended Medicare to cover end-stage renal disease, solving an urgent problem — people were dying because they could not pay — by paying per treatment delivered in a facility. Fifty years on, the United States has a large, capital-intensive in-center hemodialysis industry, the great majority of patients start in a center, and home modalities remain the minority path even though they cost less and better preserve residual kidney function. The clinic real estate, the staffing ratios, the training pipeline, and the referral habits all grew up around that payment structure. None of it was anyone’s intent, and that is precisely why exhortation fails: telling nephrologists to offer home therapy treats the symptom, the structure pushes back, and the home census drifts down again once the initiative’s funding ends.

The remedies therefore have to act on the structure. Change what is paid for rather than what is asked for — a per-patient, per-month payment neutral across modality removes the revenue penalty a program absorbs when a patient goes home. Measure the right interval, modality at ninety days and at twelve months rather than at start, so the metric rewards keeping patients home instead of merely enrolling them. Relieve the constraint that actually binds, which is the supply of home training nurses rather than patient interest. And, most in the spirit of the chapter, make the question part of every decision: before adopting a fix, write down what structure it will create that someone will have to undo in twenty years. Yesterday’s solutions were not stupid; they were just never asked that question.